COLOSSIANS · STUDY 05 OF 12

Colossians 2:1–7

The Believer's Education

Christ Is All — A Study of Colossians

Small Group Bible Study Series · NASB95

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① Text	② Devotional	③ Commentary	④ Self-Study Guide
Foundation	Personal preparation	Teacher / leader preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	*All group members*	*Teacher / leader*	*Small group*

⑤ *Application closes each study and draws from all sections above.*

Time guide: about 30 minutes — Devotional 4 · Commentary 15 · Discussion 8 · Application 3.

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① BIBLICAL TEXT

Colossians 2:1–7 · New American Standard Bible (NASB95)

2:1 *For I want you to know how great a struggle I have on your behalf and for those who are at Laodicea, and for all those who have not personally seen my face,*

2 *that their hearts may be encouraged, having been knit together in love, and attaining to all the wealth that comes from the full assurance of understanding, resulting in a true knowledge of God's mystery, that is, Christ Himself,*

3 *in whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge.*

4 *I say this so that no one will delude you with persuasive argument.*

5 *For even though I am absent in body, nevertheless I am with you in spirit, rejoicing to see your good discipline and the stability of your faith in Christ.*

6 *Therefore as you have received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk in Him,*

7 *having been firmly rooted and now being built up in Him and established in your faith, just as you were instructed, and overflowing with gratitude.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · Drawn from the outline of this study

Keep Walking the Way You Started

> *“Therefore as you have received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk in Him”*
> *— Colossians 2:6 (NASB95)*

How did you receive Christ? Not by climbing a ladder of rules, not by mastering secret knowledge, and not by earning God's favor. You received Him by faith, as a gift of grace. Paul's simple counsel to the Colossians is this: keep walking the same way you started.

The false teachers did not tell the Colossians that Jesus was wrong. They told them He was not enough. Paul answers that in Christ "are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge." There is no treasure outside of Him that you need to go looking for. Every riches of understanding is found by going deeper into Christ, not beyond Him.

So Paul gives us a picture of healthy growth. Like a tree, we are rooted in Him. Like a building, we are being built up in Him. Like a soldier holding his position, we are established in the faith. And like a river after spring rain, we overflow with gratitude.

For reflection

1. Have you ever been tempted to think that Jesus plus something else would make your Christian life complete?
2. Which picture fits your spiritual life right now: roots going down, walls going up, or a firm stand?
3. When was the last time your heart truly overflowed with gratitude to God?

You began with grace. Walk on in grace, rooted, built up, established, and thankful.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **The passage teaches:** Paul labors for believers he has never seen so that, knit together in love, they will come to the full knowledge of God's mystery, Christ Himself, in whom all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge are found, and so that they will not be deluded but will keep walking in Christ as they received Him, rooted, built up, established, and overflowing with gratitude.

Outline

- **I. Paul's Wish (2:1–3)**
  - A. The Content of the Wish (2:1a)
  - B. The People of the Wish (2:1b)
  - C. The Reason for the Wish (2:2–3)
- **II. Paul's Warning (2:4)**
- **III. Paul's Assurance (2:5)**
  - A. His Location
  - B. His Observation
- **IV. Paul's Admonition: Keep Walking in Christ (2:6–7)**
  - A. The Measure of the Walk (2:6)
  - B. The Manner of the Walk (2:7)

Introduction

Paul is continuing the thought of chapter 1. In 1:29 he said, "I labor, striving (*agōnizomenos*)." In 2:1 he uses the noun form of the same word, "how great a struggle (*agōna*) I have on your behalf." The athlete's agony of 1:29 now becomes a struggle of prayer and concern for churches Paul has never visited. This passage might be called "the believer's education": what Paul wants believers to know, how he wants them to be protected, and how he wants them to keep growing.

I. Paul's Wish (2:1–3)

A. The Content of the Wish (2:1a)

"For I want you to know how great a struggle I have on your behalf." Paul was not boasting about how much he suffered. He wanted the Colossians to know how much he loved them, and how serious the threat of the false teaching was.

B. The People of the Wish (2:1b)

"And for those who are at Laodicea, and for all those who have not personally seen my face." These were the believers of the Lycus Valley in Asia Minor.

- **The people of Colossae.** "On your behalf" refers to them; this letter is addressed to them.
- **The people of Laodicea.** Paul wanted both congregations to read both letters (4:16). The "letter that is coming from Laodicea" may well have been the letter we know as Ephesians, written about the same time and sent to the same region, perhaps as a circular letter.
- **The people of Hierapolis**, and all "who have not personally seen my face." This does not mean all believers of all time, but most of those in the region who would read these letters (cf. 4:13).

C. The Reason for the Wish (2:2–3)

"That their hearts may be encouraged." Paul does not pray that they would be healthy, wealthy, and prosperous. He prays that their hearts would be encouraged, strengthened from within. They were being pressured to add something to their free salvation. The false teachers did not tell them Jesus was wrong. They told them He was just not enough, and that they possessed a wisdom and knowledge that went beyond what Paul and Epaphras had taught. How would believers be strengthened against that? Paul gives three steps.

1. The prerequisite: hearts knit together in love

"Having been knit together in love." The participle (*symbibasthentes*) is in the aorist tense, which may suggest this is the first step in the process, or even that their hearts had already been knit together. Love had made them one body, and now a common enemy threatened them. Either way, coming together in love is the starting place. Believers who stand alone are easy prey; believers knit together are hard to pull apart.

2. The sub-purpose: the wealth of full assurance of understanding

"And attaining to all the wealth that comes from the full assurance of understanding." The idea is not merely acquiring these riches, but putting them to use against the false teachers, defeating their "philosophy and empty deception" (2:8) and their mere "appearance of wisdom" (2:23). "Full assurance" (*plērophoria*) speaks of settled conviction, the opposite of being tossed by every new idea.

3. The final purpose: the knowledge of God's mystery

"Resulting in a true knowledge of God's mystery, that is, Christ Himself." Here the manuscripts vary considerably; the NKJV reads "the mystery of God, both of the Father and of Christ." But the point is clear in either case: the mystery is Christ (see 1:27). Paul is not describing a mystery that belongs to the Father and to Christ. He is saying that the mystery **is** Christ.

And what does Christ offer? "In whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge" (v.3). **Knowledge** is the apprehension of truth. **Wisdom** is the ability to apply that knowledge to the best advantage. Scripture speaks of wisdom in several ways: the wisdom given to Paul and his fellow workers (1:28; 2 Pet. 3:15), the pretended wisdom of the false teachers (2:23), and the wisdom of God Himself.

God's wisdom reconciles what seem to be irreconcilable. It brings Jew and Gentile together in one body. It satisfies His justice, which demands the death of the sinner, and His love, which desires the sinner's salvation:

> *“Lovingkindness and truth have met together;*
> *Righteousness and peace have kissed each other.”*
> — Psalm 85:10 (NASB95)

Through the stumbling of Israel, God brought salvation to the Gentiles, to provoke Israel to jealousy, so that in the end "all Israel will be saved" (Rom. 11:11, 25–26). Paul's response to all of this is pure worship:

> *“Oh, the depth of the riches both of the wisdom and knowledge of God! How unsearchable are His judgments and unfathomable His ways!”*
> — Romans 11:33 (NASB95)

That wisdom and knowledge are available in the mystery, and the mystery is Christ. The word "hidden" (*apokryphoi*) may well be a deliberate jab at the false teachers, who prized "hidden" books and secret teaching. Paul says the real hidden treasures are not stored in a secret society. They are stored in Christ, and every believer has Him.

II. Paul's Warning (2:4)

"I say this so that no one will delude you with persuasive argument." The verb "delude" (*paralogizomai*) means to reason falsely, to cheat by false reasoning. "Persuasive argument" (*pithanologia*) is plausible, smooth talk. The false teachers followed Paul and his associates and tried to add their philosophy to the gospel. That has been the pattern of every cult throughout Church history, and it has not stopped in the twenty-first century.

Watch out for the plausible arguments. One of the most common today is the claim that all religions are equally true paths to God. We gladly honor every person's freedom to believe as they choose, but no one has the right to change what the Bible teaches. We have the inspired Word of God, which tells us that Jesus is "the way, and the truth, and the life; no one comes to the Father but through Me" (John 14:6). Salvation is by grace, through faith, plus not one thing (Eph. 2:8–9).

III. Paul's Assurance (2:5)

A. His Location

"For even though I am absent in body, nevertheless I am with you in spirit." Paul could not be with them. He was a prisoner in Rome. But he did not give up. He was still being used by the Lord as the apostle to the Gentiles. Absence did not stop him from praying for them and sending them the Word God had revealed to him for their encouragement and growth.

B. His Observation

"Rejoicing to see your good discipline and the stability of your faith in Christ." Paul saw them through the eyes of Epaphras. Both words carry a military flavor.

- **Good discipline** (*taxis*) is good order, an army in its ranks. The Colossians' ranks had not been broken. Paul was not hurrying to a church in disorder, as was the case in Corinth, nor was this a church "so quickly deserting" the gospel, as in Galatia (Gal. 1:6).
- **Stability** (*stereōma*) is a solid front, a firm line that does not give way. The firmness of their faith was the reason for their good order. They still believed the gospel of their salvation. They had been taught that salvation is a gift, that no works are necessary. So when someone came saying, "These works are necessary," they could simply answer, "No works are necessary!"

IV. Paul's Admonition: Keep Walking in Christ (2:6–7)

A. The Measure of the Walk (2:6)

"Therefore as you have received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk in Him." This is one of the key verses of the letter. Paul is able to tell them, in effect, "Keep on doing what you are doing." The way you began is the way you continue: by faith in Christ. Compare his fearful words to the Corinthians and his amazement at the Galatians:

> *“But I am afraid that, as the serpent deceived Eve by his craftiness, your minds will be led astray from the simplicity and purity of devotion to Christ. For if one comes and preaches another Jesus whom we have not preached, or you receive a different spirit which you have not received, or a different gospel which you have not accepted, you bear this beautifully.”*
>
> — 2 Corinthians 11:3–4 (NASB95)

> *“I am amazed that you are so quickly deserting Him who called you by the grace of Christ, for a different gospel;”*
>
> — Galatians 1:6 (NASB95)

Notice the full title, "Christ Jesus the Lord." The false teachers had a reduced Christ. The Colossians had received the Messiah, the man Jesus, who is Lord of all.

B. The Manner of the Walk (2:7)

Paul piles up four participles to describe the walk, and three of them are passive. The believers did not do these things for themselves; by their faith they allowed God to do them in them.

1. Firmly rooted in Him

Errizōmenoi, a perfect passive participle: rooted once and remaining rooted. The taproot of a tree goes down, more and more. Our roots were set in Christ when we believed, and they stay there.

2. Now being built up in Him

Epoikodomoumenoi, a present passive: being built up continually. A building goes up, story by story, and the Master Builder is doing the work. The picture switches from a tree to a building, but both are "in Him."

3. Established in your faith

Bebaioumenoi, present passive: being made firm, confirmed. This is the result of the first two. "Your faith" here likely includes the body of truth they had believed, "just as you were instructed." Being rooted and built up results in being confirmed in the doctrine we hold.

4. Overflowing with gratitude

Perisseuontes, and this one is active. Overflowing with thanksgiving is something we do. We are to be thankful for all the Lord has given us and for all the experiences, even the hard ones, that have brought us to where we are. Thanksgiving is one of the clearest marks of a believer who knows that Christ is enough.

Conclusion

Paul's education for believers is simple and deep. Be knit together in love. Get to know Christ fully, because every treasure of wisdom and knowledge is hidden in Him. Do not be talked out of the truth by persuasive arguments. Keep your ranks and stand firm. And keep walking in Christ the same way you received Him, by grace through faith, rooted, built up, established, and overflowing with gratitude.

The next verses will show us exactly what kind of "persuasive argument" Paul had in mind. But the defense is already in place: Christ is enough.

Lord, thank You.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Grammar and parsing: Blue Letter Bible. Sources cited selectively: STR (Strong's), THAY (Thayer's), ATR (A. T. Robertson), VINE (Vine's), MRV (Vincent's), LXX (Septuagint usage).

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
v.1	**ἀγών** *struggle*	**G73** *agōn* Acc. Masc. Sg.	**VINE:** a contest, conflict; the athletic arena. **Significance:** Picks up "striving" from 1:29; Paul's concern for unseen believers is a real contest.
v.2	**παρακαλέω** *encouraged*	**G3870** *parakaleō* Aor. Pass. Subj. 3rd Pl.	**THAY:** to call alongside; to strengthen, comfort. **Significance:** Paul prays for inner strength, not outward prosperity.
v.2	**συμβιβάζω** *knit together*	**G4822** *symbibazō* Aor. Pass. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Pl.	**THAY:** to join together, unite; used of the body's joints in 2:19. **Significance:** Love unites believers into a body that is hard to divide.
v.2	**πληροφορία** *full assurance*	**G4136** *plērophoria* Gen. Fem. Sg.	**VINE:** fullness, abundance; settled conviction. **Significance:** Firm conviction of the truth protects against being tossed by error.
v.3	**θησαυρός** *treasures*	**G2344** *thēsauros* Nom. Masc. Pl.	**STR:** a deposit, treasury, wealth. **Significance:** Every treasure of wisdom and knowledge is stored in Christ.
v.3	**ἀπόκρυφος** *hidden*	**G614** *apokryphos* Nom. Masc. Pl.	**MRV:** possibly a jab at the false teachers' "hidden" lore. **Significance:** Hidden in Christ, not in a secret society; available to every believer.
v.4	**παραλογίζομαι** *delude*	**G3884** *paralogizomai* Pres. Mid. Subj. 3rd Sg.	**THAY:** to reckon wrong, to deceive by false reasoning. **Significance:** False teaching cheats believers through faulty logic.
v.4	**πιθανολογία** *persuasive argument*	**G4086** *pithanologia* Dat. Fem. Sg.	**STR:** persuasive language. Only here in the NT. **Significance:** Plausible speech can sound right and still be wrong.
v.5	**τάξις** *good discipline*	**G5010** *taxis* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**MRV:** orderly array, as of soldiers in rank. **Significance:** The Colossians' ranks had not been broken.
v.5	**στερέωμα** *stability*	**G4733** *stereōma* Acc. Neut. Sg.	**THAY:** firmness, a solid front. **Significance:** A firm line of faith in Christ that does not give way.
v.6	**παραλαμβάνω** *received*	**G3880** *paralambanō* Aor. Act. Ind. 2nd Pl.	**VINE:** to receive, often of receiving teaching handed down. **Significance:** They received Christ and the truth about Him; walk the same way.

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
v.7	**ῥιζόω** *firmly rooted*	**G4492** *rhizoō* Perf. Pass. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Pl.	**ATR:** perfect: rooted once and remaining so. **Significance:** The believer's roots were set in Christ at faith and stay there.
v.7	**ἐποικοδομέω** *being built up*	**G2026** *epoikodomeō* Pres. Pass. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Pl.	**ATR:** present: continuous building upon a foundation. **Significance:** God keeps building the believer, story by story.
v.7	**βεβαιόω** *established*	**G950** *bebaioō* Pres. Pass. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Pl.	**STR:** to make firm, confirm. **Significance:** Rooted and built up, believers are confirmed in the faith they were taught.
v.7	**περισσεύω** *overflowing*	**G4052** *perisseuō* Pres. Act. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Pl.	**THAY:** to abound, overflow. **Significance:** The one active participle: gratitude is the believer's own response.

Grammar key — Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. Verb Mood: Ind. · Imp. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Review prompt	From the commentary
How does 2:1 connect to 1:29?	"Striving" (*agōnizomai*) in 1:29 becomes "struggle" (*agōn*) in 2:1.
What three steps lead to strengthened hearts (v.2)?	Knit together in love; the wealth of full assurance; the true knowledge of God's mystery, Christ.
What is the mystery, according to 2:2?	Christ Himself.
What do "good discipline" and "stability" picture?	Soldiers in unbroken ranks and a firm, solid line of faith.
Name the four participles of 2:7.	Rooted (perfect passive), built up (present passive), established (present passive), overflowing (present active).

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. What was the false teachers' basic claim about Jesus, and why is it so dangerous?

> **Leader's answer:** Not that Jesus was wrong, but that He was not enough; believers needed a deeper wisdom. It is dangerous because it sounds respectful of Christ while denying His sufficiency

and adding to grace.

2. Why might Paul have chosen the word "hidden" in verse 3?

Leader's answer: The false teachers likely prized hidden, secret knowledge. Paul turns their term around: the true hidden treasures are in Christ and available to every believer.

3. What "persuasive argument" might threaten believers today, and how does Scripture answer it?

Leader's answer: One common example is that all religions are equally valid paths to God. Jesus answers, "I am the way … no one comes to the Father but through Me" (John 14:6), and salvation is by grace through faith alone (Eph. 2:8–9).

4. What does it mean to walk in Christ "as you have received" Him (v.6)?

Leader's answer: We received Him by faith as a gift of grace, not by works or special knowledge. We are to keep living the same way, depending on Him by faith rather than switching to a system of rules or secrets.

5. Three of the four participles in verse 7 are passive and one is active. Why does that matter?

Leader's answer: Rooting, building, and establishing are God's work in us as we trust Him; we do not produce them ourselves. Overflowing with gratitude is our active response. Growth is God's doing; thankfulness is ours.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verses	Theme	Key truth
2:1–3	Paul's wish	He struggles for unseen believers, that they be knit in love and know Christ, the treasury of wisdom.
2:4	Paul's warning	Let no one delude you with plausible arguments.
2:5	Paul's assurance	Though absent, he rejoices in their good order and firm faith.
2:6–7	Paul's admonition	Walk in Christ as you received Him: rooted, built up, established, overflowing with thanks.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · personal and corporate

1. Stay Knit Together

Scripture anchor: Colossians 2:2

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, I.C.1

Believers who are knit together in love are hard to pull apart. Isolation makes us vulnerable to discouragement and error. The first defense Paul names is not a doctrinal argument but loving fellowship.

Reflection: Are you knit into a group of believers who know you well enough to notice if you drift?

Practical step: Reach out to one member of your group this week simply to encourage them.

2. Look Deeper into Christ, Not Beyond Him

Scripture anchor: Colossians 2:3, 6

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, I.C.3, and ② Devotional

Every treasure of wisdom and knowledge is hidden in Christ. Spiritual growth is never moving past Jesus to something more advanced; it is digging deeper into who He is and what He has done. Beware of any teaching that offers "the next level" outside of Him.

Reflection: Have you been looking for spiritual answers somewhere other than Christ and His Word?

Practical step: Read Colossians 1:15–2:3 slowly this week and list every treasure you find in Christ.

3. Walk the Way You Started

Scripture anchor: Colossians 2:6; Galatians 3:3

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, IV.A; cf. Swindoll, The Grace Awakening (FGR)

You received Christ by grace through faith. Chuck Swindoll has warned for years against "grace killers" who welcome people in by grace and then load them with performance. The Christian life is lived the same way it is entered: by faith in Christ, not by a list of rules.

Reflection: Do you ever feel that God loves you more on your "good days" than on your hard ones?

Practical step: Each morning this week, pray: "Lord, as I received You by grace, help me walk in You by grace today."

4. Overflow with Gratitude

Scripture anchor: Colossians 2:7

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, IV.B.4, and ④ Study Question 5

Gratitude is the one active participle in verse 7. God does the rooting, building, and establishing; we give the thanks. A thankful heart is evidence of a believer who knows Christ is enough.

Reflection: Which of your recent experiences, even hard ones, can you thank God for?

Practical step: Write down ten things you are thankful for in Christ and share three of them with your group.

End of Study · Colossians 2:1–7